

ON TECHNIQUE

Pioneer of electronic music

Stockhausen was particularly noted for his groundbreaking work in electronic music in the 1950s. At that time, there was a heated debate as to whether the future lay in the purely electronically synthesized sounds produced in the German studios, or *musique concrète*, electrically modified recorded sounds, favored by the French studios. In *Gesang der Jünglinge* (Song of the Youths, 1955–1956), Stockhausen found ways to integrate the techniques, combining electronically generated sounds with a recorded human voice and its electronic transformations, using multiple-channel recording to explore the spatial positioning of sound as an integral parameter of the music.

Stockhausen was born in Mödrath, near Cologne. His early childhood was marred by the fact that his mother was admitted into a psychiatric institution in 1932. Another tragedy befell the Stockhausen family that year, when Karlheinz's younger brother, Hermann, died.

Matters did not improve when, in 1938, his father remarried. His new wife was the family's former housekeeper, a situation that the 10-year-old Karlheinz found unbearable. Then, in 1941, his mother died. The official cause of death was given as leukemia, but it is probable that she had been gassed by the Nazis.

Continuing turmoil